A Strange Treasure

Aesop (adapted)

Old John Crabtree was the owner of the biggest orchard in his part of the country. He was also the father of three strong, but lazy, sons.

Old John looked after his fruit trees with very little help from his sons. Early every morning, while they were still in bed, the old man could be found working alone in the orchard. He dug the soil, cut away all the useless branches from the old trees, carefully tended the young trees, and picked all the fruit at harvest time.

Every evening after his work, he would sit on a log and rest in the shade of his trees. Old John would gaze and gaze at the long rows of apple trees, pear trees, and plum trees. Then he would sigh to think that soon he would be too old to give them all the care they needed.

"Dear me!" he would say to himself. "It is a great pity. I wish my sons would work in the orchard. If they did, I am sure that the fruit would bring them a fortune."

There came a time when John no longer worked among his fruit trees, for he took ill and died.

Not long after his death, the three sons met to hear what money their father had left to them. The reading of his will amazed them, because there was only this one sentence:

"The orchard, and the treasure which is there, I leave to my three sons."

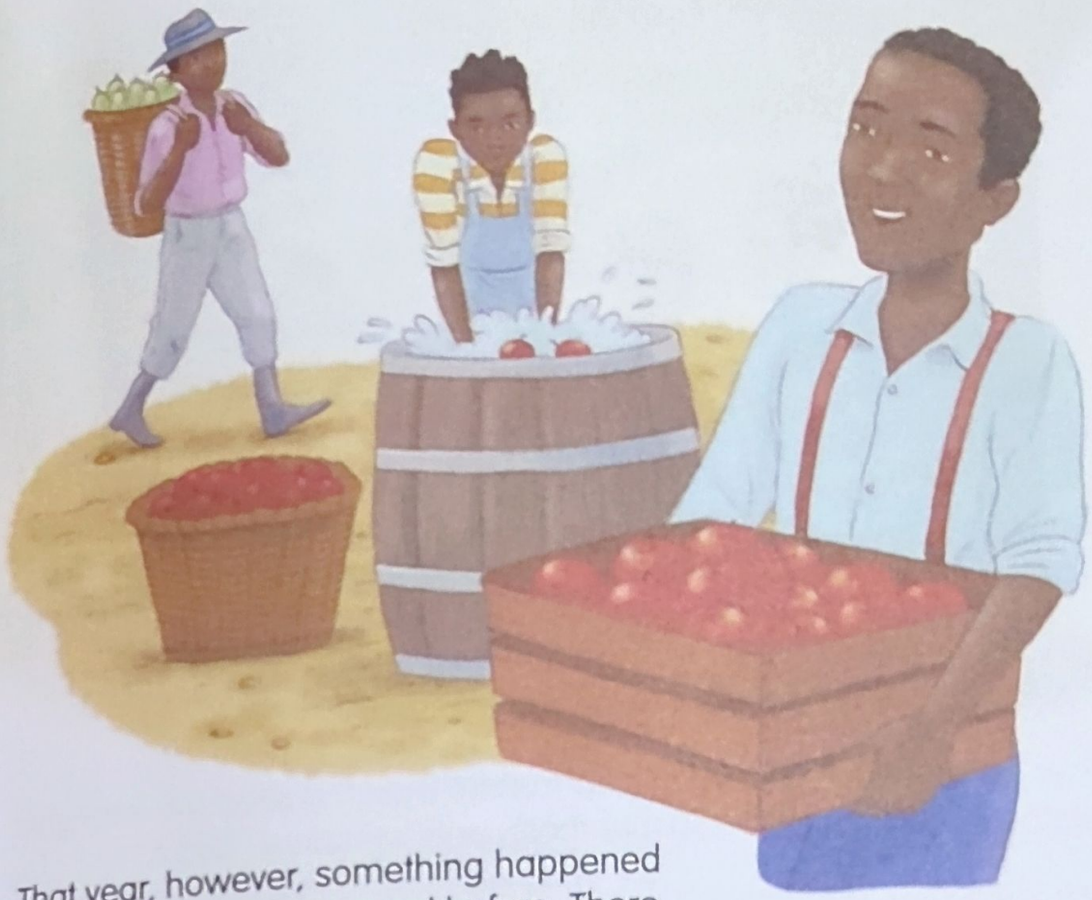
The sons stared at each other in astonishment. "Treasure!" they shouted. "Isn't that wonderful? We will be rich! Father has hidden his money in the orchard!"

"We must be very careful," said the eldest son. "If we tell others of this, they might steal the treasure from us."

"What shall we do?" asked the youngest son.

"We must tell no one about the treasure," said the middle son. "We will dig and search in the orchard until we find it."

The sons then made their plans to find the treasure. They divided the orchard into three parts, and worked as they had never worked before. They carefully dug the soil from one end of the orchard to the other. They even turned over the earth around the roots. Not an inch did they miss. Alas! After days, and weeks, and months of digging and searching, no treasure was found.



That year, however, something happened which had never happened before. There was so much fruit on the trees, that the branches were bent almost to the ground. The three sons were delighted. Never had they seen such a crop of apples and pears and plums.

When harvest time came, the sons were kept very busy. The youngest son picked the ripe fruit from the trees, the middle son cleaned it, and the eldest son packed it carefully into boxes. The fruit was then sold to merchants for a very good price.

So much money did they get, they became quite rich.

One day the eldest son said to his brothers, "I wonder what our father meant when he said there was a treasure in the orchard?"

"Our father was a very wise and truthful man," replied the youngest brother. "There must be treasure there, only we cannot find it."

"Do you know what I think?" said the middle brother. "Father knew that we were very lazy, and would not take care of the fruit trees. If he said there was treasure in the orchard, he knew that we would dig and search for it. By our digging, we helped the trees to give us such a wonderful crop of fruit."

"Yes," replied the eldest brother. "I think that you are right. Father was very clever. The fruit has brought us a great deal of money and made us rich."

Each year, the three sons worked hard in the orchard. They found no money hidden in a box below the ground, but each year the orchard gave them another kind of treasure.

Comprehension skills

1 Where is the story set?
a) a farm b) a palace c) an orchard

2 Find the lines in the story that describe four jobs that John Crabtree did.

3 Which word best describes the three sons?
a) hardworking b) lazy c) helpful

4 Why did the eldest son say that they must be careful?

5 What plan did the sons come up with?

6 How long did they spend carrying out their plan?

7 Why were the branches of the trees bent almost to the ground?

8 What crops did the sons harvest? Name three.

9 What words does the youngest son use to describe his father?

10 What words does the eldest son use to describe his father?

Critical literacy

Thinking about the story

1 There was never any buried treasure in the orchard, but John did leave his sons treasure in another way. What do you think the real treasure was? What lesson do you think the sons have learned from their father?

Thinking beyond the story

2 An orchard is a plantation of fruit trees. What fruits do you most like to eat? Draw a picture of your two favourite fruits. Inside each fruit write a short description of it; you could write about the texture, colour, taste or smell of the fruits.

Language development

1 Which of these are fruits:
carrot, orange, daisy, banana, rose, cabbage, mango, cherry, turnip, tulip, grape, onion, lemon?

2 What colour is a ripe
a) banana
b) apple
c) plum
d) strawberry
e) pear
f) gooseberry?

3

One	**More than one**
leaf	_____
man	_____
foot	_____
daisy	_____
tooth	_____

4 We say 'an orchard of fruit trees'.
Put these words in their right places:
string, matches, jam, milk, cards, drawers.
a) a jug of _____
b) a pack of _____
c) a pot of _____
d) a box of _____
e) a ball of _____
f) a chest of _____

5 Old John was **not lazy**.
Give one word instead of the two words in bold type.
a) The spelling was **not easy**.
b) The door was **not open**.
c) The sum was **not right**.
d) The paper was **not clean**.
e) The coat was **not wet**.